

Nintendo Battling Wii Shortages

The Wii is the hottest selling console around, but having a product sell like hot cakes around the world can cause a whole new set of problems—Nintendo is battling to produce enough Wiis for the upcoming holiday season, and factories are working overtime. They're not complaining, though!



Hell Freezes Over

The Xbox actually outsold the PS3 in Japan in the second week of November! It's true though, and apparently, the Xbox was able to beat PS3 sales for the week (17,673 vs 17,434 units) mainly because of Namco's game, *Ace Combat 6: Fires of Liberation*.



Newsbytes



DirectX 10.1

What is it?

DirectX 10.1 is a revision of the DirectX 10 (DX10) graphics specification, due out soon with Vista Service Pack 1.

Which systems can run DX10?

DX 10.1 can only be used on Vista systems with SP1. Those without SP1 use DX 10.

How significant is it?

DX 10.1 adds specs that were optional in DX 10—for example, 32-bit FP filtering.

When will you use it?

With next-generation games based on it, on supported hardware, DirectX 10.1 will offer a new level of graphics quality. Currently, ATI has released graphics cards that are DX 10.1 capable, but games that utilise the DX 10.1 specification properly are yet to be built. Currently, we're still waiting for Vista SP1, and hoping that the rumours of Microsoft trying to make DX 10.1 compatible with XP are true.

Who developed it?

Microsoft, of course, and beta testing of Vista SP1 and DirectX 10.1 is underway, with a final release date of early 2008.

Why all the hype?

Enthusiasts have spent hundreds of dollars buying top-of-the-line cards, and are worried that their cards might be obsolete. But DX 10.1 games will function on DX 10 cards, but new features of DX 10.1—if a game utilises them—will fall back to the DX 10 method of rendering. Basically, games will play, but will not look as good as on a DX 10.1 card.

CONSOLE WOES?

Sony Attempts To Rescue PS3

The console wars continue. While the Xbox 360 is riding the *Halo 3* wave, and the Wii is enjoying tremendous sales because of its revolutionary new style of controller (being the cheapest console helps too), the Sony PS3 has been struggling...

Consider the sales figures: Microsoft's Xbox has been on the market the longest—two years—and has sold close to 13.5 million units thus far. The Sony PS3 and Nintendo Wii were launched at approximately the same time—one year ago—with the PS3 selling a mere 5.6 million units thus far. The Wii, however, is king of the console ring by a huge margin. Nintendo has shipped over 13.2 million units—and will soon overtake the Xbox 360 in terms of total sales.

The Wii has never had to cut prices, or even depend on huge game titles

to increase sales—being unique has always paid off. The Xbox sales have doubled because of *Halo 3*—so even though Microsoft sells its 360 at loss (as do most console manufacturers), they're more than making up for this with huge titles such as *Halo 3*—they made \$170 million (Rs 680 crore) on *Halo 3* sales, on the day of the launch alone!

Meanwhile, the PS3 languishes with no real console-selling games and the distinction of being the most expensive console. Recently, however, they decided to cut the price of the PS3, and the 80 GB model is being sold for \$100 (Rs 4,000) cheaper than the original \$599 (Rs 24,000) price. But a price cut is not all they need, and execs at Sony knew they needed some great games to help sell their console. Even right here in India, despite

all the consoles being available—officially or in the grey—as are a lot of the games, people are buying more Xboxes and Wiis than PS3s, because they aren't really interested in the games that are available on Sony's platform.

Sony decided to combat this by cutting prices on its PS3 Software Development Kit—by 50 per cent! The "Reference Tool" (Sony's nomenclature

of the PS3 SDK) is now available to game developers for \$8,600 (Rs 3,44,000) in Japan, \$10,250 (Rs 4,10,000) in North America and \$11,250 (Rs 4,50,000) in Europe. They're hoping that this lowering of the bar will bring in newer game developers, who will hopefully increase the number of games for the PS3.

Incidentally, those who already own PS3s need not worry about the future of the platform, because Sony's not likely to give up on their technological marvel in a hurry. Besides, it's still the best deal you can get on a 1080p Blu-Ray DVD player!

GIRLS N GAMES

Why Girls Don't Like Gamers

If you haven't heard of Jade Raymond, we congratulate you. You're one of the few gamers left who couldn't care less about anything but the game you're playing. You're not interested in the name of the developer, or how good she looks. Unfortunately, most of us geeks and gamers seem sexually starved to the point of desperation.

Jade Raymond is the producer of Ubisoft's popular game *Assassin's Creed*. Now it's customary for the producer or head developer to talk

about the game to the media, so Jade is the one everyone interviewed. Unfortunately, people noticed that she was "hot", and every search you do for Jade Raymond online will inevitably point you to a blog or forum that says something like, "Jade Raymond is hot".

Conspiracy theorists and the generally paranoid, however, feel that Ubisoft is exploiting Jade's stunning looks to cause a stir and promote the game, and always making sure that all interviews regarding

ate.. tiv.. influence behind *Assassin's Creed*. Please buy my game" It then depicts her providing...err... "lip service"—the most tasteful way we can say it—in exchange for gamers agreeing to buy the game. The cartoonist may have been trying to express how he feels Ubisoft is fooling gamers into buying a game based on how hot the producer is, but there's a line he crossed.

Jade's not happy, and with her game a runaway success, Ubisoft is not too happy either. Lawsuits



Assassin's Creed are held with her. Now we're not naive enough to think that Ubisoft's management didn't realise that Jade has above-average looks, and marketing campaigns the world over use beautiful people to sell their products—we're not crying foul, it's just business.

Now Jade was probably a little embarrassed with all the publicity her "hotness" got her, or maybe she wasn't, and actually enjoyed it—we don't know her to be able to tell you. However, no woman would like to be depicted pornographically—except for porn stars of course.

Unfortunately, a sexually overcharged member of the www.somethingawful.com forum decided to make a sexually explicit cartoon depiction of the way he thought Jade was promoting her game. The cartoon has Jade in a bikini saying, "Hi boys! I'm Jade, Producer and crate... uh...crate.. erm.. cray-

were filed, the offensive image was removed from the Something Awful forums (not from the member's DeviantArt page), and blogs everywhere crying fair or foul.

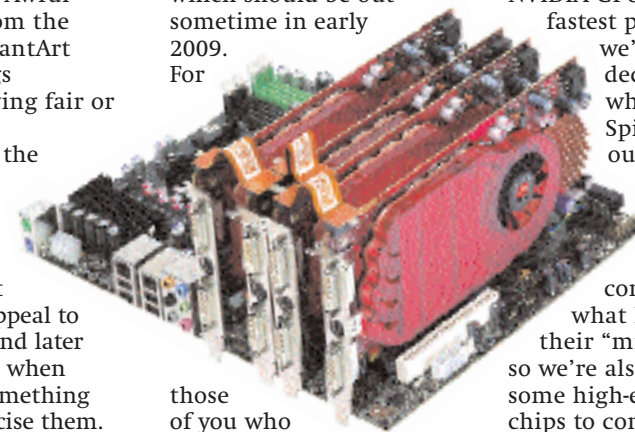
Some are of the opinion that Jade and Ubisoft are being hypocrites—first using her sex appeal to sell the game, and later acting offended when someone did something creative to criticise them. Others even go so far as to say that it's all a publicity stunt, and Ubisoft is the one behind the offensive cartoon in the first place. Some are defending Ubisoft and Jade vehemently, using abusive language on forums where members have discussed her "hotness" before. It's become such a big issue that even we're

forced to report it to you. However, make no mistake. Through this article, through the millions of others online, in print, on TV even, where ever this development is being discussed, there are some Ubisoft executives rubbing their hands together in glee—although unfortunate, sick even, the "Jade cartoon" is giving Ubisoft some great publicity for *Assassin's Creed*.

THE PHENOM

AMD Launches Spider

AMD's much awaited quad-core, the Phenom, was launched last month. However, AMD also launched its Spider platform—which is basically an AMD (or ATI) graphics card, a CPU and a chipset that work together to provide higher visual quality and better graphics. Spider is the first step that AMD is taking towards their Fusion platform, which should be out sometime in early 2009. For



those of you who don't know, Fusion is AMD's futuristic chip that can take on both normal processing and graphics processing, making it a hybrid chip of sorts.

To coincide with their Phenom launch, AMD released the ATI Radeon HD 3850 and HD 3870 cards. The 3850 features 256 MB of RAM

HOT
Core Control
New games are finally making use of the dual cores and quad cores that people have been buying for over a year already. Now it is making sense to opt for that quad core if you're a serious gamer.

Upgrade Woes
None of the 8800s and 8600s that gamers have bought so far will run DX 10.1-based games the way they should be run. In a year's time, all those folks are going to have to upgrade again...

while the 3870 has double that. These are among the first cards to support DirectX 10.1, and AMD hopes that with Spider, they can start getting their graphics and processor engineers to start working more closely together to bring out a better platform for gaming and HD video.

Early benchmarks still showed Intel chips with NVIDIA GPUs to be the fastest performing, but we'll reserve our decisions for when we get Spider to test for ourselves.

Interestingly, the new cards are priced in comparison to what NVIDIA prices their "mid-range" chips, so we're also waiting for some high-end AMD / ATI chips to come our way.

For general computing and us technology consumers, AMD seems to be sticking to its plan of building its Fusion platform. This is good news for us because it mean cheaper chips and lower power bills. We're hoping performance will improve as well. You're going to have to watch this space for more though.